

A Golden Anniversary in Virginia Wine Country



Barboursville Vineyards celebrates 50 years of world-class wines and more.



By DAWN KLAUVON

A few special places in Virginia seem to exist outside of time—where landscape, history, and hospitality converge to create something enduring, even idyllic. Barboursville Vineyards is one of them.

Rustic yet refined, the renowned estate offers an experience as memorable as its wines. Visitors come to taste award-winning vintages, dine on chef-curated cuisine, and linger amid one of the Commonwealth's most beautiful and serene landscapes.

This year, Barboursville Vineyards celebrates its 50th anniversary, marking five decades as one of the pioneering estates that helped define modern Virginia wine. At the heart of that story is Luca Paschina, the Italian-born winemaker and estate director who has guided Barboursville for nearly 36 years.

On a spring visit, Paschina steers his SUV off the paved road and onto red clay paths that wind through the vineyards. As the tires crunch over the dirt, he points out subtle changes in elevation, where cold air settles, which vines escaped the season's late frost, and how each block will mature in the months ahead.

"This is about farming and handcrafted wines," he says.

To ride through the vineyards with Paschina is to understand that, for all its elegance, Barboursville remains first and foremost a farm. Great wine begins with close observation, patience, and a willingness to adapt to nature.

"You don't have control," Paschina says. "You can adapt to it."

That philosophy has helped produce some of the most respected wines in the country.

"What I like best is planning, working in the vineyard, blending wine, and sharing a story with people."

—Luca Paschina, Estate Director and Winemaker, Barboursville Vineyards



The winery's flagship Bordeaux-style blend, Octagon, recently earned international acclaim when the 2017 vintage was recognized by wine magazine and website Decanter as one of the top wines in the U.S. and recommended as one of the world's finest cellar-worthy bottles. The estate's story began in 1976, when Italian wine entrepreneur Gianni Zonin purchased the historic property and saw potential in Virginia's rolling Piedmont landscape. His investment helped lay the

foundation for what would become one of the state's most influential wineries.

In 1990, Paschina arrived from Italy when Virginia was still an unlikely place for fine wine. What he found was a vision already beginning to take root.

Patrick O'Connell, chef and proprietor of The Inn at Little Washington and longtime friend of Paschina, has watched Barboursville elevate Virginia's culinary reputation in much the same way his own restaurant transformed perceptions of fine dining in the Commonwealth.

"I was honored to be a guest at the 50th anniversary celebration for Barboursville Vineyards," O'Connell says. "We have had a long and fruitful friendship with Luca Paschina through the decades and enjoyed many wonderful collaborations. We're so proud of our neighbors at Barboursville for uplifting Virginia's reputation as a producer of internationally acclaimed fine wines."

Like O'Connell, Paschina understood early that exceptional wine alone would not be enough.

"I told them, it's not going to work by buying advertising," Paschina says. "It's going to work if we are able to get people to come here, have a great experience, and then have a great meal."

That vision transformed Barboursville into far more than a winery. Guests can savor estate vintages and Italian fare at Palladio Restaurant, then settle into the gracious 1804 Inn at Barboursville Vineyards and its charming cottages, where vineyard views and quiet mornings create a true sense of escape. Nearby, the storied Barboursville Ruins, once a mansion designed by Thomas Jefferson, lend another layer of history and romance to the landscape.

